Ukraine: Zelensky holds firm despite US pressure

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Ukraine will resist Trump’s pressure, betting the US will avoid seriously damaging cuts. President Volodymyr Zelensky views the risk of a full US inte||||||||||||||||

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Ukraine will absorb US pressure and keep hitting refineries

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Ukraine will keep striking Russian refineries despite US pressure, betting that Washington will stop short of cuts that seriously damage its war effort.

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If President Donald Trump does cut support for Ukraine, he will likely start with deep-strike intelligence, which would make the refinery campaign costlier and less effective.

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A combined cutoff of battlefield intelligence, Starlink, and arms support would be the most severe option and would turn dangerous for Ukraine if it coincided with a major Russian escalation on the front.

Ukraine will resist Trump’s pressure, betting the US will avoid seriously damaging cuts. President Volodymyr Zelensky views the risk of a full US intelligence cutoff as low, hoping the political cost will deter the most severe reversal. Kyiv and its European backers want a mutual energy ceasefire, not a one-sided limit that benefits Russia (see: Trump-Putin deal won’t impact diesel prices or produce an energy ceasefire , 12 October 2026). Zelensky will keep criticizing Trump to rally support at home and abroad.

Trump's erratic approach means cuts could come in any form, at any time, or not at all. The pressure appears to be coming largely from Trump personally, while the broader administration seems divided. The swift reversal of the Starlink restriction could suggest a miscommunication or a change of heart. Republican pushback against deep cuts to intelligence or the Prioritised Ukraine Requirements List (PURL) could also restrain Trump and prevent a worst-case outcome.

If Trump is willing to absorb the blowback from Republicans, Europe, and possibly the US public, he has a range of options. The mildest would withhold specific capabilities and early strike warnings; the most severe would end arms sales, all offensive and defensive intelligence, and technical support.

The most likely target is intelligence supporting Ukraine’s deep strikes. As the dispute began over attacks on Russian refineries, this would be the most logical target. It remains unclear whether the 13-14 October Starlink outage marked a first step. Some reports suggest the outage aimed to disrupt drones flying toward refineries while still on Ukrainian territory, although it mainly affected Ukraine’s mid-range strikes.

If Washington ends deep-strike support, Ukraine's refinery strikes will continue but lose effectiveness. US intelligence helps Kyiv plan drone routes, altitude, and timing to evade Russian air defenses and monitors mobile launchers. Credible estimates of Russia's interception rate suggest it downs or jams roughly 90% of Ukrainian long-range drones. Without US support, that share would rise. Distant, heavily defended targets in the Moscow region and at major export hubs would be most impacted. A slower strike tempo would give Russian refineries time to complete repairs between attacks and restore output.

Still, Kyiv and its European backers view the campaign as central to their leverage over Moscow and are unlikely to suspend it completely.

Cutting battlefield intelligence would raise Ukrainian losses but would not guarantee a Russian breakthrough. The Starlink restriction already shows how even a narrow restriction spills over onto the battlefield. It disrupts mid-range drones striking Russian logistics and air defenses in occupied territory, as well as interceptor drones deployed against Russia's jet-powered drones.

A full shutdown would be more significant, with Washington choosing to weaken Ukraine at the front. Units would lose much of their reconnaissance and communications. Washington could also press other US technology providers, such as Palantir. Together with cuts to battlefield intelligence, these losses would raise Ukrainian casualties, make Ukraine ineffective against moving targets, and give Russia room to resupply and make limited gains.

While a full shutdown remains unlikely given the political cost to Trump within his own party and with the public, a credible threat of one could push Kyiv to pause deep strikes on refineries.

The real danger would come from a prolonged loss of intelligence coinciding with Russian escalation. A full general mobilization and an offensive remain unlikely but would allow Russia to benefit most from the outages (see: Escalation between Russia and Ukraine coming in the autumn , 3 September 2026). Ukraine's own drones cover the front line, but US intelligence reveals reserves, supply hubs, and troop buildups deeper behind Russian lines. Without that intelligence, a Ukrainian military already short of troops could neither strike Russian forces as they mass nor redeploy in time.

A PURL suspension would leave Ukrainian cities more exposed to Russian strikes this winter. Patriot interceptors, already in short supply, would be impacted. A broader cutoff would also threaten Ukraine's F-16 fleet, which relies on US-made missiles, parts, and maintenance and serves as a key defense against jet-powered drones. Fewer interceptions would mean more casualties and more successful strikes on energy infrastructure. Deliveries arrive monthly or even twice a month, with no buffer of Patriot, air-to-air, or other missiles, so a freeze would bite immediately.

Europe will speed up diversification, but the hardest gaps will persist. Since 2025, European governments have expanded intelligence and weapons support. But Europe cannot yet replace space-based missile warning, the depth of US signals intelligence, and support for US-made weapons. The episode will push Europe to diversify more seriously and further erode trust in the US as a reliable partner after a period of improving relations.

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